



INVICTUS NASHVILLE CHARTER SCHOOL

EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK

2026-2027

This handbook applies to all Invictus Nashville Charter School employees.

Questions? Contact us at hr@invictus-nash.org.

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Employee Handbook · 2026–2027 academic year

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SECTION 01

WELCOME TO INVICTUS NASHVILLE

A Note from Leadership

Welcome to Invictus Nashville Charter School. We're glad you're here.

Every person on this team — whether you're leading a classroom, running operations, or supporting students behind the scenes — plays a real role in what we're building. Our students and families are counting on us to show up, do the work with integrity, and care about the community we serve.

This handbook is your guide to working here. It covers what we expect, what you can expect from us, and how we handle everything from your first day to your daily work to the moments that are harder to navigate.

Please read it carefully. And if you ever have questions, reach out — we'd rather you ask than guess.

Our Mission

Invictus Nashville will prepare our K–8 students to become engaged members of society by helping them identify their unique path to personal and professional freedom. Through a diverse culture, personalized learning, and community service, Invictus Nashville graduates will be equipped with the necessary habits of success and a heart for service in their communities.

Our Vision

To cultivate college- and career-ready young adults with a diverse worldview who will become leaders in their communities.

Our Core Beliefs

- Families and students are vital partners in shaping the educational journey.

- Exposure to a wide range of learning experiences equips students for real-world challenges.
- Strong academic and professional habits lay the foundation for long-term success.
- Students should understand the world beyond their neighborhoods — thinking globally, acting locally.

About This Handbook

This handbook outlines our policies, practices, and expectations as an employer and school community. It's meant to be clear and readable — not a legal maze.

A few important things to know:

- This handbook is **not a contract** and does not guarantee employment for any period of time.
- It doesn't cover every possible situation. When something isn't addressed, reach out to your manager or the Director of Operations.
- Policies may be updated at any time. Changes will be communicated promptly.
- Verbal assurances from any employee do not override what's written here.



Questions? Contact us at hr@invictus-nash.org or speak with the Director of Operations.

SECTION 02

YOUR EMPLOYMENT

At-Will Employment

Employment at Invictus Nashville is **at-will**. That means either you or the school can end the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause and with or without advance notice. Nothing in this handbook changes that relationship.

Employee Classifications

Your classification determines your eligibility for certain benefits and pay practices.

● Full-Time

Regularly scheduled to work 30 or more hours per week.

● Part-Time

Regularly scheduled to work fewer than 30 hours per week. Not eligible for most benefits.

● Exempt (Salaried)

Not eligible for overtime pay. Typically teachers, instructional leads, and managers.

● Non-Exempt (Hourly)

Eligible for overtime pay (1.5× rate) for hours worked over 40 per week.

● School Calendar

Works during the academic year only (typically 10 months). Receives summer pay if employed through the final school day.

● Calendar Year

Works 12 months. Eligible for 10 days of PTO annually.

Classifications may be reviewed and adjusted if your role or scheduled hours change. The school reserves the right to modify classifications consistent with applicable wage and hour laws. Any reclassification will be communicated in writing.

Certification Requirements

Tennessee law requires educators serving in positions requiring licensure to hold an appropriate and valid Tennessee educator license, permit, or other state-approved authorization for their assignment.

STAFF AGE REQUIREMENT

In compliance with Tennessee Child Care Standards, Chapter 0520-12-01-.07(3), all teachers, assistant teachers, directors, and assistant directors must be at least **21 years of age** at the time of hire. This requirement applies to staff hired after June 30, 2017, and includes substitutes serving in teaching roles.

Employees serving under a practitioner license, temporary permit, or while enrolled in a State Board-approved Educator Preparation Program (EPP) are considered compliant when authorized by the Tennessee Department of Education in accordance with applicable state law and State Board rules.

All licensed or state-authorized instructional staff are responsible for maintaining active credentials and meeting all renewal, program, testing, and compliance requirements applicable to their licensure pathway. Documentation of current licensure or program status must be provided to Human Resources upon request and updated as required.

Employees must notify Human Resources **immediately** if:

- A license or permit lapses
- Renewal requirements are not met
- Enrollment or standing in an educator preparation program changes
- The employee becomes aware of any issue that could affect state authorization to teach

Failure to maintain appropriate state authorization for employment may result in reassignment, unpaid leave, or disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

Montessori Certification — Arete Residency Program

Invictus Nashville is a Montessori school. Teachers who are not yet Montessori certified are expected to complete an approved certification program. The school sponsors eligible employees' participation in the **Arete Memphis Public Montessori Residency Program**, a MACTE-accredited program that includes coursework, coaching, mentorship, field supervision, and in-person summer residencies.

Sponsorship may cover approved expenses including tuition and program fees, housing during required in-person sessions, meal and per diem support, certification and exam fees, and approved transportation costs. The estimated total sponsorship investment is approximately **\$13,150 or more** depending on actual costs incurred.

What this means for you

- Certification is awarded to you personally and is yours to keep regardless of where you work.
- Coursework, assignments, and practicum requirements are your individual responsibility to complete.
- You are expected to remain employed at Invictus Nashville for **two (2) academic years** following the beginning of residency-supported employment.
- If you voluntarily resign, voluntarily withdraw from the program, or are terminated for cause before completing the two-year commitment, a repayment obligation may apply based on actual costs incurred by the school.
- Repayment amounts are tiered based on your departure timing and are governed by the terms of the separate MOU, not this handbook.
- Regular wages, salary, and benefits are **never** subject to repayment.

Repayment exceptions

Repayment obligations do not apply in cases of reduction in force, position elimination, non-renewal unrelated to misconduct, medical inability to continue, relocation due to military orders, documented family emergency, or other circumstances approved by school administration.

IMPORTANT

Participation in the Arete Residency requires signing a separate Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with Invictus Nashville. That document governs the specific financial terms, repayment schedule, and conditions of sponsorship. Nothing in this handbook modifies or supersedes that agreement. Nothing in that agreement alters the at-will nature of your employment.

SECTION 03

GENERAL WORKPLACE INFORMATION

Work Hours

Employee schedules are determined by the needs of the school and may vary by role. Unless otherwise communicated by a supervisor, employees are expected to be present, prepared, and ready to work by **7:30 a.m.** and remain on campus until **4:00 p.m.**

The student instructional day is generally:

Mon–Wed & Friday	7:30 a.m. – 3:20 p.m.
Thursday	7:30 a.m. – 2:20 p.m. (shortened day)

Shortened-day Thursdays are designed for professional development and may include required trainings, meetings, collaboration, or other responsibilities extending beyond the student day, potentially until **4:30 p.m.**

Employees may also be required to attend additional events outside regular hours, including open houses, family engagement events, conferences, trainings, or other school functions. Advance notice will be provided whenever possible, and attendance at designated required events is considered part of professional responsibilities.

Schedules may occasionally change based on operational or instructional needs. Employees with alternative schedules will receive direction from their supervisor.

Inclement Weather

Invictus Nashville generally follows Metro Nashville Public Schools (MNPS) for weather-related closures and delays. Monitor local news when weather events are expected.

- If MNPS closes or delays school, Invictus Nashville will do the same unless otherwise communicated.

- If school is closed, employees are not expected to work remotely.
- If school is open and you cannot report to work, you must use PTO or receive manager approval.

Equal Employment Opportunity

Invictus Nashville is committed to a diverse, inclusive, and respectful work environment. We do not discriminate on the basis of race, religion, creed, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, national origin, color, age, veteran status, disability, or any other protected characteristic under applicable law.

This commitment applies to all aspects of employment: hiring, compensation, advancement, discipline, and separation. If you believe you have been discriminated against, use the Problem Resolution process described in Section 6.

Religious Accommodations

We will make reasonable accommodations for sincerely held religious beliefs and observances, unless doing so creates an undue hardship on school operations. Submit accommodation requests in writing to hr@invictus-nash.org.

Disability Accommodations

We comply fully with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). If you need a workplace accommodation, submit a written request to hr@invictus-nash.org. Requests will be reviewed and accommodations will be made when reasonable and appropriate.

Personnel Records

Your personnel file is maintained by the Director of Operations and is confidential. Only individuals with a legitimate business need may access it.

- To update your information or request access: hr@invictus-nash.org
- Please keep your address, contact details, and licensure information current in Paylocity.

Employment Verification

All employment verification requests must go through the Director of Operations or Head of Schools. We confirm: (1) dates of employment, (2) job title, and (3) salary (with employee consent). Send requests to hr@invictus-nash.org.

Personal Property

Employees are responsible for securing and safeguarding their personal belongings while on school property or participating in school-related activities. Invictus Nashville Charter School is not responsible for lost, stolen, damaged, or misplaced personal items, including items allegedly taken or damaged by students, staff, visitors, or third parties.

Employees are encouraged to avoid bringing valuable or unnecessary personal items to campus and should not leave personal belongings unattended in shared or unsecured spaces.

School Property & Privacy Notice

Lockers, desks, filing cabinets, storage areas, and school-issued devices are school property. The school reserves the right to search or inspect any school property at any time, with or without notice, for any legitimate business reason.

- Employees have no expectation of privacy in school-owned spaces or on school-issued systems.
- This includes email, files, browsing history, and any content stored on INCS devices or accounts.
- Personal items may be stored on campus at your own risk. The school may inspect school property areas even when personal items are present.

THIS APPLIES TO EVERYONE

This policy applies to all employees, contractors, and volunteers, regardless of role or tenure.

Lactation & Nursing Accommodations

Invictus Nashville supports nursing employees and complies with federal and Tennessee law regarding lactation accommodations.

- Reasonable break time will be provided for employees to express breast milk for up to one year following the birth of a child.
- A private, clean space that is not a bathroom will be made available for this purpose.
- To request accommodations, notify the Director of Operations in writing. Requests will be handled confidentially and accommodations arranged promptly.

Lactation breaks taken beyond standard scheduled break times may be unpaid for non-exempt employees, consistent with applicable law. Speak with the Director of Operations if you have questions.

Internal Communications Expectations

Clear, timely communication is essential in a school environment. All employees are expected to:

- Check school email at least twice daily during contracted work hours — once in the morning and once before end of day.
- Respond to manager communications within one business day unless otherwise specified.
- Respond to urgent or emergency communications from leadership as promptly as possible, regardless of time of day.
- Use only approved school communication platforms (school email, approved messaging apps) for all work-related communication. Personal platforms are not approved channels for school business.
- If you will be unavailable for an extended period, notify your manager in advance and set an out-of-office response.

EMERGENCY COMMUNICATIONS

In the event of a school emergency or urgent safety situation, you are expected to respond to leadership communications immediately, even outside of normal hours. Failure to do so may affect your ability to fulfill emergency response assignments.

SECTION 04

CONDUCT & PROFESSIONALISM

Role Model Policy

Every Invictus Nashville employee — regardless of role — is a role model. Whether you're teaching, managing operations, or supporting students in any capacity, your behavior sets the tone for our school community.

We expect all employees, volunteers, and contractors to:

- Understand that their behavior influences student behavior and outcomes.
- Demonstrate professionalism, respect, and integrity consistently.
- Refrain from engaging in illegal, unethical, or harmful conduct.
- Uphold all Invictus Nashville policies, including those related to harassment, child safety, and substance use.
- Maintain a public and social media presence that aligns with our standards, even when off duty.

A GOOD TEST

If your behavior — online or in person — would raise concerns if seen by a student or family, it's worth reconsidering.

Reporting Inappropriate Behavior

Every employee has a shared responsibility to protect students and the integrity of our school community. If you witness, experience, or learn of any behavior that is inappropriate, unsafe, or in violation of policy — you are required to report it.

This includes:

- Suspected child abuse or neglect

- Unprofessional or unethical staff behavior
- Violations of harassment, substance use, or safety policies
- Anything that compromises our mission, culture, or student safety

You may report to your direct manager, the Director of Operations, or the Head of Schools. You do not need proof to report a concern. If something doesn't feel right, say something.

RETALIATION IS PROHIBITED

Any employee who reports a concern in good faith is protected. Retaliation is strictly prohibited and grounds for discipline up to and including termination.

General Standards of Conduct

We expect all employees to maintain high standards of professionalism and accountability. The following behaviors may result in disciplinary action, up to and including immediate termination:

- Insubordination or refusal to follow reasonable direction from a supervisor
- Breach of confidentiality involving student, staff, or organizational information
- Negligence or actions that endanger the safety of others
- Theft, fraud, or unauthorized use of school property
- Dishonesty, including falsification of records or time entries
- Harassment or discrimination of any kind
- Violent, threatening, or intimidating behavior
- Consistent failure to meet job performance expectations
- Violation of state or federal law while on school grounds or conducting school business
- Interference with an investigation or failure to cooperate with leadership

This list is not exhaustive. Some situations may warrant immediate termination depending on severity.

Harassment Policy

Invictus Nashville is committed to a workplace free from harassment of any kind. Harassment — verbal, physical, visual, or written — has no place here.

Harassment includes but is not limited to:

- Unwelcome comments, jokes, or gestures based on race, gender, sexual orientation, religion, disability, or any other protected characteristic
- Offensive visual materials or messages in the workplace or shared digitally
- Persistent behavior that creates a hostile, intimidating, or offensive environment

Sexual harassment also includes unwanted sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, or any verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature that affects an individual's employment or work environment.

Harassment doesn't require intent — it's about impact. If you experience or witness harassment, report it immediately. All reports will be taken seriously and investigated.

Consensual Relationships

Invictus Nashville discourages romantic or sexual relationships between employees when a supervisory or power dynamic exists. If such a relationship develops, it must be disclosed to the Director of Operations or Head of Schools so appropriate steps can be taken to prevent conflicts of interest or bias.

Consensual relationships between coworkers of equal standing are not prohibited, but all employees must maintain professional behavior on campus and during school business at all times.

Attendance & Punctuality

Our students and teammates depend on you to be present and on time. Consistent attendance is essential.

Expectations

- Arrive on time and ready to work at the start of your scheduled shift.
- If you cannot report to work or will be late, notify your manager no later than one hour before your scheduled start time.

Planned Absences

- Planned absences must be submitted in Paylocity at least two weeks in advance whenever possible.
- Requests must be approved by your manager within the Paylocity system before the absence is considered authorized.

Unplanned Absences

- Unplanned absences must be recorded in Paylocity as soon as possible.
- Employees must notify their manager by phone no later than one hour before their scheduled start time.
- Email alone is not sufficient unless pre-approved by the manager.
- Provide updates if your absence extends beyond one day.

Repeated unexcused absences may result in progressive discipline.

If you're struggling with attendance due to a personal or medical issue, speak with your manager or HR. We're here to help support you through the right process.

Appearance Guidelines

We don't have a strict dress code, but we do expect staff to dress professionally and appropriately for a school environment.

What's expected

Clothing should be neat, clean, and professional. Avoid clothing with offensive language, political statements, or inappropriate graphics. Footwear should be safe and functional for your role.

What's flexible

Hair styles, textures, and cultural dress. Tattoos and piercings (unless imagery is offensive or inappropriate). Gender-affirming attire and accessories.

If you're ever unsure, check with your manager. Concerns will be addressed with care and discretion.

Outside Employment & Conflict of Interest

You may hold outside employment as long as it does not interfere with your responsibilities at Invictus Nashville or create a conflict of interest.

What we ask

- Your role at Invictus Nashville comes first. Outside work must not affect your performance, schedule, or availability.
- You may not use school resources, materials, or confidential information for outside employment.
- You may not promote or operate an outside business during work hours or on school grounds.

- If there is any chance your outside work could conflict with your role here, disclose it to your manager before proceeding.

Conflict of Interest Standards

Employees must avoid situations where personal interests conflict, or appear to conflict, with the interests of Invictus Nashville. Any potential conflict should be disclosed to a manager as soon as possible.

- Employees may not use their position for personal financial gain.
- Employees may not make decisions involving vendors, contracts, or purchases where they have a personal or financial interest without disclosure and approval.
- In limited circumstances, employees may provide approved contracted services to the school outside of their regular job responsibilities. These arrangements must be disclosed, approved in advance, and managed separately from the employee's regular duties.
- The formal annual Conflict of Interest disclosure process applies to Board members.

Fitness for Duty

All employees are expected to report to work physically, mentally, and emotionally prepared to perform their duties safely. If you are taking medication that may impact your ability to work or perform specific responsibilities, notify your supervisor. You are not required to disclose the medication name or condition — only whether it affects your job performance.

Drug-Free Workplace

Invictus Nashville maintains a drug-free and alcohol-free workplace.

Prohibited conduct

- Using, possessing, selling, or distributing illegal drugs or controlled substances on school property or while representing the school
- Reporting to work under the influence of alcohol or drugs
- Misusing prescription medications
- Possessing or using alcohol on school grounds or at school events without prior approval

Testing

Under Tennessee law (T.C.A. § 50-9-100 et seq.), drug testing is not a required condition of employment at Invictus Nashville. However, the school reserves the right to require testing in the following circumstances: (1) pre-employment, where applicable to the role; (2) reasonable suspicion, where a manager has documented, observable evidence of impairment; and (3)

post-incident, where a workplace safety incident has occurred. Refusal to submit when testing is reasonably required, or a confirmed positive result, may lead to disciplinary action including termination.

If you're dealing with a substance use issue, you're encouraged to seek confidential support through the Emotional Wellbeing Solutions (Here4TN) program included with our health benefits. Services are available 24/7 through Optum Behavioral Health. See Section 9 for details.

Tobacco-Free Environment

Smoking and all tobacco use is prohibited on school property and at any school-sponsored events, regardless of location. This includes cigarettes, cigars, vapes, e-cigarettes, and smokeless tobacco. This policy applies to all employees, contractors, volunteers, and visitors.

Weapons-Free Workplace

Invictus Nashville maintains a zero-tolerance policy for weapons on school grounds. In accordance with T.C.A. § 39-17-1309, no employee may bring a firearm, knife, explosive, or any weapon onto campus — including parking areas and school-sponsored events. This includes employees with valid carry permits. The only exception is sworn law enforcement officers acting in their official capacity. DHS rules contain no exception permitting weapons in DHS-regulated program spaces based on administrative authorization.

Workplace Violence & Threat Prevention

Invictus Nashville is committed to a safe, threat-free environment for all employees, students, and visitors. Violence and threatening behavior have no place in our school community.

The following are strictly prohibited and may result in immediate termination and referral to law enforcement:

- Physical violence or assault against any person on school property or at school events
- Verbal or written threats of violence, harm, or intimidation
- Aggressive conduct intended to frighten, coerce, or harm another person
- Possession of any weapon in violation of the weapons-free policy above

Employees are also expected to report concerning behavior — even when it has not yet escalated to a direct threat. If you observe an employee displaying a pattern of alarming, threatening, or erratic behavior, report it to the Head of Schools or Director of Operations immediately. Reports will be taken seriously and handled with discretion.

DO NOT WAIT

You do not need to be certain that violence will occur to report a concern. Reporting early is always the right call. The school will evaluate all reports and take appropriate action.

Investigation Cooperation

When Invictus Nashville conducts an internal investigation — whether related to a complaint, a policy concern, a workplace incident, or any other matter — all employees are expected to cooperate fully and honestly.

This means:

- Responding promptly to requests for information from leadership or designated investigators
- Providing truthful and complete information to the best of your knowledge
- Maintaining confidentiality about the investigation unless authorized to discuss it
- Not retaliating against or pressuring anyone who has reported a concern or participated in an investigation

Failure to cooperate, providing false information, or attempting to interfere with an investigation are serious violations that may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination — independent of the outcome of the investigation itself.

Background Checks

All employees must complete criminal background screening, fingerprinting, and all required state agency clearances as a condition of employment, in compliance with T.C.A. § 49-5-413 and other applicable Tennessee laws and regulations. This includes requirements associated with both school employment and Department of Human Services (DHS)-regulated programming under Tennessee Child Care Standards, Chapter 0520-12-01-.07(15).

Because Invictus Nashville operates a DHS-regulated child care program, three separate clearances are required for all employees prior to beginning employment:

- TBI/FBI criminal background check and fingerprinting
- Tennessee Department of Health Vulnerable Persons Abuse Registry check
- TBI/FBI Sex Offender Registry check

Each of these checks has its own process and timeline. All three must be completed and cleared before an employee may assume any duties with students. No employee may work unsupervised with students until all three clearances are confirmed. In limited cases where an

agency determination is pending despite timely submission, the Director of Operations will determine appropriate work restrictions or supervision requirements on a case-by-case basis, as required by law or agency regulation.

Employees are responsible for scheduling and completing required fingerprinting and background check appointments as directed by the Director of Operations prior to their start date. Invictus Nashville Charter School will reimburse employees for approved background check and fingerprinting costs. Reimbursement is processed through payroll after the employee's start date, upon submission of required documentation or receipts.

All employees are required to submit new fingerprints every five years per TDOE rules and applicable agency regulations. The Vulnerable Persons Registry and Sex Offender Registry checks are subject to their own re-check schedules as required by the applicable agency. The school will notify employees in advance of all rescreening deadlines. Failure to complete required rescreening may result in removal from duties pending compliance.

A failed background check or failure to comply with screening requirements may result in disciplinary action or termination of employment. All Criminal History Records Information (CHRI) is strictly confidential. Misuse, whether intentional or accidental, may result in disciplinary action, termination, and/or legal prosecution.

Physician Health Clearance

In compliance with Tennessee Child Care Standards, Chapter 0520-12-01-.05(f)(3), all new employees must submit a completed physician health clearance form verifying fitness to work with children in a group care setting within **10 calendar days** of their start date. The form must be completed and signed by a licensed physician, nurse practitioner, physician assistant, or other qualified healthcare provider.

Updated health clearance is required every three years of employment. Documentation is maintained in the employee's personnel file and is not shared with other staff. Employees who do not submit required health clearance documentation within the established timeline may be placed on unpaid leave until the requirement is fulfilled.

Pre-Service Orientation

In compliance with Tennessee Child Care Standards, Chapter 0520-12-01-.07(5), all new employees must complete a minimum two-hour pre-service orientation before beginning duties with students. This requirement applies to all staff, substitutes, and volunteers with student access, regardless of prior experience or credentials.

Orientation must cover the following topics and completion must be documented in the employee's personnel file:

- School program philosophy and mission
- Emergency procedures and evacuation protocols
- Discipline policies and behavior management expectations
- Child abuse and neglect reporting procedures
- SIDS (Sudden Infant Death Syndrome) safe sleep procedures, where applicable
- Child dismissal and release policies

Employees may not work unsupervised with students until pre-service orientation is complete and documented.

Annual Staff Training Requirements

In compliance with Tennessee Child Care Standards, Chapter 0520-12-01-.07(6), all employees must complete annual training within the first two weeks of employment and each year thereafter on the following required topics:

- Child abuse and neglect detection, reporting, and prevention
- Parent and family-centered communication practices
- Disease control and infection prevention
- Certificate of approval requirements and compliance obligations
- Infection risks to employees of childbearing age
- Food allergy recognition and response
- Supervision of children during high-risk activities, including eating, outdoor play, and water activities
- Meal service and safe food preparation
- Shaken baby syndrome & abusive head trauma
- Safe sleep procedures (SIDS prevention)
- Developmentally appropriate practices
- Discipline and supervision policies

Completion of all required annual training must be documented in each employee's personnel file and is subject to review by TDOE and DHS. Training records are maintained by the Director of Operations. Employees who do not complete required annual training within the established timeframe may be subject to work restrictions pending compliance.

Proprietary Information

During your employment, you may access confidential information about students, staff, operations, or finances. You are expected to keep this information confidential during and after your employment and use it only for official school business.

Examples include student records, employee evaluations, internal reports, and donor data. Unauthorized disclosure may result in disciplinary action, including termination and legal action.

SECTION 05

TECHNOLOGY, MEDIA & COMMUNICATIONS

Technology Loan Agreement

INCS provides school-issued technology, including laptops, accessories, and related equipment, to employees whose roles require it. These devices remain the property of Invictus Nashville Charter School and are provided to support instruction, communication, collaboration, and school operations.

By accepting or using a school-issued device, employees acknowledge and agree to comply with this Technology Loan Agreement and all related school technology policies.

Employee Responsibilities

Employees are expected to:

- Maintain devices in reasonable working condition
- Use school-issued technology primarily for work-related purposes unless otherwise approved
- Protect devices from theft, damage, unauthorized access, or misuse
- Keep passwords and login credentials secure and confidential
- Transport and store devices responsibly
- Return all devices, chargers, accessories, and related equipment upon request or before the final day of employment
- Promptly report any loss, theft, malfunction, or damage to the Director of Operations or designated technology support staff

Employees should not delay reporting accidental damage or technical issues. Many school-issued devices are covered through AppleCare or other support plans, and early reporting often allows the school to resolve issues quickly and minimize disruption.

Damage, Loss & Negligence

Normal wear and accidental damage may be covered through AppleCare, warranty protection, or school insurance at the discretion of INCS. However, employees may be held financially responsible for damage or loss caused by negligence, intentional misuse, unauthorized modifications, repeated carelessness, or failure to promptly report an issue. INCS reserves the right to determine whether damage or loss falls under normal accidental use or negligence.

NOTE

All activity on school-issued devices, networks, and accounts is school property and may be monitored or reviewed. Employees should have no expectation of personal privacy on INCS systems.

Technology & Acceptable Use

INCS technology systems are for professional use supporting instruction, communication, and operations.

Prohibited use includes

- Sending, storing, or sharing harassing, discriminatory, or offensive content
- Downloading, viewing, or distributing sexually explicit material
- Using pirated, illegal, or unlicensed software
- Attempting to access systems, accounts, or files without authorization
- Sharing passwords or failing to safeguard login credentials
- Uploading malicious software, viruses, or code
- Circumventing school security systems or monitoring tools
- Using school technology in ways that violate law or school policy

Employees may not download or install unauthorized software, applications, extensions, or security tools without approval from the Director of Operations or designated technology staff.

Monitoring & Privacy

All activity conducted on school-issued devices, networks, systems, email accounts, internet services, and communication platforms is school property and may be monitored, accessed, reviewed, or retained by INCS at any time, with or without notice, to the extent permitted by law. Employees should have no expectation of personal privacy when using INCS technology resources, even if occasional personal use is permitted.

Ownership of work

All files, documents, and materials created during your employment are the property of Invictus Nashville. Before your last day, ensure your manager has access to all work files and can locate where they're stored.

Recording, Photography & Media Use

As part of classroom instruction, student documentation, communication, and school operations, employees may occasionally photograph, record, or upload approved student work, classroom activities, or school events using authorized school platforms and procedures. All recordings, photographs, and media involving students or employees must be handled responsibly and in accordance with student privacy expectations, school policy, and any applicable consent requirements.

● Authorized use may include

Classroom documentation and Montessori work observations; student portfolio documentation; school communications or marketing approved by leadership; staff trainings or operational purposes approved by administration; uploading content to approved educational platforms or student information systems.

● Employees may not

Secretly record conversations or meetings involving employees, students, or families; record students or staff for personal, social media, or entertainment purposes; share student images or recordings outside approved school systems without authorization; store sensitive student media on unsecured personal devices; distribute recordings in ways that violate privacy expectations or school policy.

Employees should use school-approved platforms whenever possible and are expected to remove or appropriately transfer student-related media from personal devices once uploaded or no longer needed for legitimate school purposes.

Consent & Privacy

Media involving students may only be used in accordance with parent/guardian permissions and school procedures. Employees are responsible for respecting all media opt-outs, confidentiality obligations, and student privacy protections. Unauthorized recording, misuse, or distribution of recordings or images may result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

Media Inquiries

All media inquiries must be referred to the Head of Schools or Director of Operations. Only the Head of Schools, Director of Operations, or a designated representative is authorized to make or approve public statements on behalf of Invictus Nashville.

- If contacted by the media, politely decline to comment unless you have been expressly authorized.
- Do not engage in “off the record” conversations.
- Do not share student details, confidential information, or operational updates without prior approval.

STUDENT MEDIA ACCESS

Media access to students requires prior written consent from a parent or guardian.

Social Media Policy

Invictus Nashville Charter School respects employees’ rights to engage in personal social media use. At the same time, employees are expected to exercise professionalism, sound judgment, and discretion online, recognizing that online conduct may affect students, families, coworkers, and the broader school community.

We encourage employees to celebrate and support the school’s mission, events, and successes in positive and appropriate ways while maintaining professional boundaries and protecting student privacy.

Expectations

- Understand that online content may become public and permanent, even if originally shared privately
- Maintain professionalism when referencing the school, coworkers, students, or families
- Protect student confidentiality and privacy at all times
- Respect professional boundaries in online interactions with students and families

● **Employees may**

Share or repost official school content, announcements, events, and celebrations; participate in approved school communication or classroom platforms used for educational purposes; engage positively with school-sponsored social media content in a professional manner; share classroom activities or student work when consistent with school procedures and applicable media permissions.

● **Employees may not**

Post student photos, names, or identifiable information outside approved platforms or without authorization and consent; share confidential or sensitive student information; imply official representation of INCS without authorization; use INCS branding in misleading ways; engage in hostile, threatening, discriminatory, harassing, or unprofessional online conduct; establish inappropriate private social media relationships with current students outside approved platforms.

School-approved educational and communication platforms used for instruction, classroom communication, student portfolios, or family engagement are permitted when used in accordance with school expectations and administrative guidance. Nothing in this policy is intended to interfere with employees' rights under applicable law.

Political Activity

Invictus Nashville Charter School recognizes that employees may participate in civic engagement, advocacy, and political activity as private citizens. As a public charter school, INCS must remain politically neutral in its official operations and may not use school resources to support or oppose political candidates or partisan campaign activity. Nothing in this policy is intended to prevent employees from engaging in lawful political activity, advocacy, or public discussion on their own time and in their personal capacity.

● **Employees may**

Participate in political or community activities on personal time; volunteer for campaigns, advocacy organizations, or civic causes in a personal capacity; express personal political opinions through personal speech, social media, or community involvement; participate in professional advocacy related to education, public policy, or charter schools when acting as private citizens or authorized representatives.

● **Employees may not**

Represent the school in partisan political activity unless specifically approved by the Head of Schools; use their position, title, or school affiliation to imply official endorsement of a candidate or campaign; conduct campaign-related activities using school time, property, email, or resources; use students or instructional settings for political campaign activity; wear INCS-branded attire implying official endorsement while participating in partisan campaign activities unless approved.

INCS may participate in lawful advocacy, legislative engagement, or public education efforts related to its mission, students, and charter school operations when authorized by school leadership and consistent with applicable law.

Ethics & Reporting

Invictus Nashville is committed to integrity, transparency, and full compliance with all applicable laws. All employees are expected to report, in good faith, any suspected or known misconduct, including:

- Theft, fraud, or financial misrepresentation
- Abuse or misuse of school funds, property, or resources
- Falsified financial reporting
- Harassment or violations of law
- Anything that compromises our mission or legal compliance

Report concerns to your manager, the Director of Operations, or the Head of Schools. If the concern involves the Head of Schools, contact the Board Chair at boardchair@invictus-nash.org.

NON-RETALIATION & WHISTLEBLOWER PROTECTION

Employees who raise concerns in good faith are protected under this policy and under Tennessee's whistleblower protection law (T.C.A. § 50-1-304), which prohibits retaliation against employees who report violations of state law to appropriate authorities. Reports made with malicious intent are a violation of this policy and may result in disciplinary action.

SECTION 06

DISCIPLINE & PROBLEM RESOLUTION

Problem Resolution

When concerns arise, we encourage employees to speak up promptly and respectfully.

General workplace concerns

Raise the issue with your direct manager first. If it's unresolved or involves your manager, escalate to the Head of Schools.

Serious concerns (harassment, discrimination, legal violations)

- Report immediately to the Head of Schools and Director of Operations.
- Submit a written description of the concern with relevant details.
- Outcomes will be communicated to the employee and relevant parties.
- If the concern involves the Head of Schools, report to the Board Chair at boardchair@invictus-nash.org.

Progressive Discipline

Invictus Nashville uses a progressive discipline model when appropriate. Leadership also reserves the right to skip steps or take immediate action depending on the severity of the situation.

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Verbal Counseling

The manager addresses the concern, clarifies expectations, and documents the conversation. The employee acknowledges and commits to corrective action.

2**2****Written Warning**

A formal written notice outlining the violation, prior verbal counseling, expectations going forward, and potential consequences. The employee signs to acknowledge receipt (not agreement). A copy goes into the personnel file.

3**3****Final Warning or Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)**

A final written warning or a structured PIP with specific benchmarks, timelines, and consequences. Leadership provides coaching and documents progress.

4**4****Suspension**

Temporary removal from duties (duration at leadership discretion). The terms of suspension and expectations for return are documented in writing.

5**5****Termination**

Written notice of termination with documentation of prior steps and infractions. The exit process is handled professionally and in compliance with state law.

NOTE FOR LEADERSHIP

Discipline at Invictus is never purely punitive. Whenever possible, consequences should be paired with coaching and support. Consistency across staff is essential.

Immediate Dismissal

Invictus Nashville reserves the right to immediately terminate any employee for serious violations, including but not limited to violence, weapons, drug use on campus, sexual misconduct, child abuse, or any conduct that places students in danger.

Solicitation

To minimize workplace disruptions, solicitation and distribution of materials are limited during working time and in working areas.

- Employees may not solicit or distribute flyers, merchandise, or literature during working hours or while employees are engaged in work duties.

- Distribution of materials in classrooms, instructional spaces, or other active work areas is not permitted.
- Nonemployees may not solicit, sell, or distribute materials on school property unless formally approved by school administration.
- Employees may not use school resources, communication platforms, or work time to operate or promote outside businesses or personal ventures without approval.

Exceptions

Employees may request approval from the Director of Operations to share resources or information that may benefit staff, such as housing resources, wellness programs, community services, or similar informational materials. Approved materials may be shared only in designated staff areas.

Leaving Invictus Nashville

Notice expectations

While not required, Invictus Nashville requests advance written notice when an employee resigns:

- **Non-management employees:** at least two (2) weeks' notice
- **Management employees:** at least four (4) weeks' notice

Your written resignation should include your intended final work date. Employees who do not provide adequate notice or who do not work through their notice period may be considered ineligible for rehire.

During the notice period, employees are expected to work all scheduled hours. Use of PTO during this time requires written approval from a supervisor. All school property must be returned before the final day of employment.

Benefits at separation

Health and other eligible benefits generally continue through the end of the month in which employment ends, subject to the terms of the applicable benefit plans.

Rehire Eligibility

Former employees who leave Invictus Nashville in good standing may be considered for rehire through the standard hiring process. Factors considered may include job performance, disciplinary history, professionalism during separation, and whether appropriate notice was provided.

Employees separated for serious misconduct, significant policy violations, or ongoing performance concerns are generally not eligible for rehire.

SECTION 07

STUDENT PROTECTION & PROFESSIONAL BOUNDARIES

Why This Section Exists

At Invictus Nashville, protecting students is not a compliance checkbox — it is the foundation of everything we do. This section consolidates our expectations around student safety, professional conduct with students, and mandatory reporting obligations. Every employee is expected to know these standards and uphold them without exception.

READ THIS CAREFULLY

Violations of the boundaries described in this section are among the most serious matters the school can face. They may result in immediate termination, referral to law enforcement, and loss of professional licensure. There is no gray area here.

Professional Boundaries with Students

All employees must maintain clear, professional boundaries with students at all times — on campus, off campus, online, and in any context where you are acting in your capacity as an INCS employee.

Transportation

- Employees are prohibited from transporting students in personal vehicles without prior written approval from school leadership.
- A signed Student Transportation Waiver must be on file before any transport occurs.
- Transporting a student without documentation is grounds for disciplinary action.

Gifts and money

- Employees may not give or accept personal gifts or cash with or from students.

- Small, classroom-appropriate items of nominal value (stickers, pencils, books) distributed equally to the class are acceptable.
- Employees may not solicit donations or financial contributions from students or families for personal benefit.

Off-campus contact

- Employees may not meet with students off campus without prior written approval from school leadership and parent/guardian notification.
- Any off-campus contact with a student in a non-school-sponsored context must be disclosed to the Head of Schools.

Communication

- All communication with students must take place through approved school platforms (school email, approved classroom apps).
- Employees may not communicate with students through personal social media accounts, personal text messages, or personal email.
- Employees may not follow, friend, or privately message current students on any personal social media platform.
- If a student initiates contact through an unapproved channel, redirect the conversation to an approved platform and notify your manager.

Physical contact

- Physical contact with students must always be appropriate to the student's age, developmental level, emotional needs, and educational setting.
- Appropriate physical interactions may include comforting a distressed child, assisting with personal care or toileting needs, supporting student safety, behavior intervention consistent with training, or other educational and caregiving responsibilities.
- Employees should maintain professional boundaries and avoid physical contact that could reasonably be perceived as excessive, secretive, sexualized, intimidating, or otherwise inappropriate.
- Be especially mindful of students with disabilities, sensory needs, trauma histories, or limited understanding of personal boundaries, and follow applicable student support plans and training.
- Any physical intervention involving student safety or significant behavioral escalation must follow school procedures and applicable training requirements.

WHEN IN DOUBT, ASK

If an interaction or situation involving a student feels unclear, boundary-sensitive, or potentially inappropriate, pause when possible and seek guidance from a school leader. Employees will not be penalized for asking questions or raising concerns in good faith.

Student Personal Care & Bathroom Assistance

Some students, particularly younger students or students with disabilities, may require assistance with toileting, diapering, changing clothes, hygiene, or bathroom-related supervision during the school day. Employees providing personal care assistance must:

- Maintain student dignity, privacy, and safety at all times
- Follow school procedures and hygiene protocols
- Use developmentally appropriate supervision and support
- Avoid one-on-one situations without reasonable visibility whenever possible
- Immediately report any concerns regarding student safety, behavior, or personal boundaries

Additional procedures and training related to diapering, toileting, hygiene support, and bathroom supervision may apply based on student age and program needs.

Mandated Reporting

As a school employee in Tennessee, you are a **mandated reporter** of child abuse and neglect under T.C.A. § 37-1-403. This is not optional — it is a legal obligation that attaches to you personally, regardless of your role or whether you have spoken to a supervisor.

You must report to DCS if:

- A student discloses abuse (physical, emotional, or sexual)
- You observe signs of abuse or neglect (unexplained injuries, fear of going home, significant changes in behavior)
- You have reasonable cause to suspect abuse — even without a disclosure

REPORT DIRECTLY TO DCS

You do not need to investigate. You do not need certainty. You do not need your manager's permission. If you have reasonable cause to suspect abuse, you report.

DCS PHONE · 24/7

1-877-237-0004

DCS ONLINE

carat.app.tn.gov/carat

AFTER REPORTING

Notify your manager immediately after making the report.

IMMINENT DANGER

Alert school leadership immediately — do not wait.

Child Abuse Coordinator

Invictus Nashville maintains a designated Child Abuse Coordinator and an Alternate Child Abuse Coordinator. These roles serve as the school's primary DCS liaison, maintain confidential records related to abuse reports, support staff navigating reporting obligations, and ensure appropriate privacy protections throughout any reporting or investigation process.

The Child Abuse Coordinator is a resource — not a gatekeeper. Contacting or notifying the Coordinator does not fulfill your personal legal reporting obligation. You are still required to report directly to DCS if you have reasonable cause to suspect abuse. Contact the Director of Operations to identify the current Coordinator and Alternate.

Consequences for failing to report

Failure to report known or suspected child abuse is a serious violation of Tennessee law and INCS policy. The consequences are significant:

- Under T.C.A. § 37-1-412, failure to report is a Class A misdemeanor, punishable by up to 11 months and 29 days in jail and fines up to \$2,500.
- Failure to report may also result in civil liability.
- Internally, failure to report is grounds for disciplinary action up to and including immediate termination, regardless of any other factors.

NO ONE IS EXEMPT

The duty to report applies to every employee — teachers, support staff, contractors, and volunteers. Telling a supervisor and assuming they will report is not sufficient. Reporting concerns internally does not remove your personal reporting obligation under Tennessee law. If you are unsure whether a report has been made, make the report yourself.

Student Disclosure of Harm

If a student reveals suicidal thoughts, self-harm, or intentions to harm another person:

- Stay calm and listen without judgment.
- Do not promise confidentiality — be honest that you will need to get help.
- Report immediately to school leadership.
- Do not attempt to assess, counsel, or manage the situation alone.
- Leadership will coordinate with trained professionals and notify the family as appropriate.

Responding to Physical Altercations

- Immediately notify the INCS leadership team.
- Employees should not physically intervene unless trained or unless necessary to prevent imminent harm.
- Verbally direct bystander students to move away.
- If safe, remain nearby and continue verbal directives.
- After the incident, submit a written report to your manager by email as soon as possible.

School Safety Expectations

- Do not prop open doors or windows.
- Do not share building access codes or keys with anyone outside of INCS staff.
- Follow all protocols outlined in the Emergency Operations Plan (EOP).
- Know the location of alarms, fire extinguishers, and evacuation routes.
- Ensure evacuation procedures are posted in your classroom or workspace.
- Secure all rooms and equipment before leaving the building.
- Do not remove, cover, or obstruct any required posting. Required postings must remain visible and accessible at all times.

EOP NOTE

The school's Emergency Operations Plan (EOP) is the authoritative document for emergency response procedures. It is confidential and not for public distribution. Familiarize yourself with the EOP protocols relevant to your role.

Required Postings — New Staff Responsibility

During onboarding, all new employees are responsible for locating and familiarizing themselves with the following required postings at their primary work location:

- Certificate of Approval (DHS program license)
- DHS complaint number for reporting concerns about the program
- DCS child abuse hotline number
- Copy of applicable State Board of Education rules
- No smoking / tobacco-free signage

If any required posting is missing, damaged, or not visible, report it to the Director of Operations immediately.

Enrollment Documentation Obligations

Staff members who assist with student enrollment are responsible for following the school's documented enrollment procedures in full. This includes offering prospective families a site visit prior to enrollment, providing the Student and Family Handbook, and obtaining a signed parent or guardian acknowledgment of receipt before or at the time of enrollment. These steps are required under TDOE program requirements and must be documented in the student's enrollment file.

Annual Compliance Training Requirements

All employees are required to complete the following training programs on an annual basis. Completion of each is documented in the employee's personnel file. Employees who have not completed current-year training requirements may not work unsupervised with students until compliance is confirmed.

Bloodborne Pathogen & Health Safety Training

Required annually under Charter Commission Policy 5400 and OSHA regulations. Training covers:

- Universal precautions for handling bodily fluids
- OSHA Bloodborne Pathogens Standard procedures
- HIV, AIDS, and infection control in a school environment
- Location and use of personal protective equipment (PPE)

Mandated Reporter Training

Required annually as a separate legal obligation from initial onboarding training. All employees must complete annual mandated reporter training on child abuse, neglect, and sexual abuse recognition and reporting procedures. This training must be documented in the personnel file each year and is not satisfied by completion of onboarding orientation alone. Training covers:

- Recognizing signs of physical, emotional, and sexual abuse and neglect
- Tennessee mandatory reporting obligations under T.C.A. § 37-1-403
- How to make a report to DCS and what to expect afterward
- Documentation and school notification procedures following a report

Failure to complete annual mandated reporter training may result in disciplinary action.

Handling Student Data (FERPA)

Student records are protected under the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA). All student information must be handled with care, professionalism, and strict confidentiality. Employees are expected to use sound judgment when accessing, discussing, storing, or sharing student information in any format, including paper files, email, messaging platforms, mobile devices, photographs, and digital systems.

Best practices

- Share student information only with authorized individuals who have a legitimate educational interest.
- Avoid including unnecessary identifying information when discussing students outside official student information systems.
- Lock or securely store physical student records when not in use.
- Cumulative files must remain in the main office or designated SPED storage areas unless otherwise authorized.
- Password-protect devices used to access school systems or student information.
- Never share student records, photographs, or personally identifiable information through unsecured platforms or with unauthorized individuals.

- Follow all school procedures related to student confidentiality, records retention, and data security.

Digital Communication & Student Information

Employees frequently use technology platforms and mobile devices to support school operations and communication. Protecting student confidentiality applies regardless of the device or platform being used.

- Student information should be communicated through school-approved systems whenever possible.
- Use caution when discussing students in group chats, messaging apps, text messages, or other informal communication tools.
- Confidential student information — disability, health, discipline, grades, or personally identifiable information — should not be shared through unsecured or unapproved platforms except when necessary to address an immediate operational or safety concern.
- In emergency or time-sensitive situations where informal tools must be used, share only the minimum information necessary and avoid unnecessary identifying details.
- Employees may not post, screenshot, forward, or distribute student information, photos, or records outside authorized school purposes.
- Personal devices used for school communication must be reasonably secured, including password protection and appropriate privacy settings.

Improper handling of student information may place both the school and individual employees at legal risk. Communications, screenshots, messages, emails, and personal devices used for school business may become subject to investigation, records review, litigation discovery, or subpoena in certain circumstances. Employees are expected to communicate professionally and thoughtfully at all times when discussing students or school operations.

Family rights under FERPA

- Families have the right to review and inspect their student's educational records.
- Families may request corrections to inaccurate information.
- Families may file complaints regarding alleged privacy violations.

Employees who violate FERPA, confidentiality standards, or school data-handling expectations may face disciplinary action up to and including termination and, in some cases, legal or regulatory consequences.

SECTION 08

COMPENSATION

Pay Schedule

Invictus Nashville uses Paylocity as its payroll and timekeeping system. Employees are responsible for reviewing and maintaining accurate payroll, tax, direct deposit, and timekeeping information within Paylocity.

Employees are paid on a **bi-weekly** schedule. Pay statements are available electronically through Paylocity and include earnings, deductions, taxes, benefits, and applicable leave balances.

Certain reimbursements, per diem support, or approved non-wage payments may be processed through payroll for administrative and reporting purposes and may be treated differently for tax-reporting purposes under applicable law. Employees should report payroll discrepancies to the Director of Operations as soon as possible.

Salary Distribution for School-Year Employees

Most school-year salaried employees are paid over **26 bi-weekly pay periods** across the calendar year for payroll consistency and budgeting purposes. This payment structure does not change the amount of compensation earned under the employee's work agreement. Compensation is earned based on the employee's contracted work period and scheduled workdays, even though pay may continue across summer months.

If employment ends before completion of the contracted work period, final compensation may be adjusted based on salary already paid compared to salary earned at the time of separation. Questions regarding salary calculations or final pay should be directed to the Director of Operations.

Contract Days & Daily Rate Calculations

Most school-year employees work under an annual contract based on a specific number of workdays. Compensation is calculated using the employee's annual salary divided by the number of contracted workdays to determine a daily rate of pay.

For payroll consistency, compensation is distributed evenly across 26 bi-weekly paychecks throughout the year. Because compensation is tied to contracted workdays, the following may be based on the employee's calculated daily rate rather than the amount of an individual paycheck:

- Unpaid leave
- Absences beyond available PTO
- Partial contract fulfillment
- Certain final pay calculations

Employees with questions regarding contract days, salary distribution, unpaid leave deductions, or final compensation calculations should contact the Director of Operations.

Timekeeping & Overtime

Non-exempt employees must accurately record all hours worked in Paylocity and comply with payroll deadlines and procedures. Overtime must be approved in advance and will be paid in accordance with applicable wage and hour laws. Misreporting hours worked or working unauthorized overtime may result in disciplinary action. Exempt employees are not eligible for overtime compensation.

TIME-AND-EFFORT CERTIFICATIONS

Employees whose compensation is funded in whole or in part by a federal grant award are required to complete semi-annual time-and-effort certifications in compliance with 2 CFR 200.430. These certifications confirm that employee time and effort were allocated consistent with the grant-funded purpose. The Director of Operations will notify affected employees of certification requirements and deadlines. Failure to submit required certifications on time may cause the school to be out of compliance with federal grant conditions. For additional detail, refer to the INCS Financial Policies and Procedures.

Professional Development Sponsorships

Invictus Nashville may sponsor employees or prospective employees for approved professional development programs, certification pathways, residency programs, conferences, training experiences, or other workforce-development opportunities. School-sponsored support may include tuition, travel, lodging, per diem support, certification costs, instructional materials, or other approved program-related expenses.

Certain sponsored opportunities may require a separate agreement outlining participation expectations, employment commitments, reimbursement terms, and/or repayment obligations for eligible sponsored expenses under certain circumstances. Unless otherwise required by law or specifically authorized in writing, regular wages, salary, and employee benefits are not subject to repayment obligations. Nothing in any sponsorship agreement alters the at-will nature of employment.

Performance Reviews & Salary Increases

Employees receive periodic performance evaluations from their direct manager. The Head of Schools is evaluated by the Board. Compensation adjustments are determined based on performance, organizational priorities, budget availability, and school needs. Annual salary adjustments, when approved, generally take effect July 1 of the applicable fiscal or school year unless otherwise communicated in writing. Final evaluations and compensation decisions are documented and communicated to employees.

Reimbursements, Mileage & Travel Support

Invictus Nashville may provide reimbursements, mileage reimbursement, per diem support, travel stipends, or direct payment of approved school-related expenses for authorized business activities, travel, training, conferences, residency programs, or operational needs. Eligible expenses may include approved travel, emergency operational purchases, mileage, lodging, meals, instructional materials, or other authorized business expenses.

The following are **not** eligible for reimbursement:

- Personal expenses
- Alcohol or tobacco products
- Gift cards unless specifically authorized
- Non-school-related costs

Mileage reimbursement is provided at the current IRS standard mileage rate for approved business travel. Normal commuting between home and the employee's primary worksite is not reimbursable.

Reimbursement requests are reviewed through the school's business office procedures, typically involving the Director of Operations and/or Office Manager. Employees may be required to submit receipts, mileage logs, or other supporting documentation. In certain situations, Invictus may use standardized reimbursement amounts, stipends, or per diem schedules instead of itemized reimbursement processes. Amounts lacking sufficient business purpose documentation may be treated as taxable compensation where required by law.

LEGAL CONSIDERATION

Compensation practices, payroll procedures, reimbursement processes, and administrative systems may change over time based on operational, financial, legal, or organizational needs.

SECTION 09

BENEFITS

Overview

Invictus Nashville participates in the Tennessee State Group Insurance Program through Partners for Health, administered by the Tennessee Department of Finance and Administration, Benefits Administration.

Eligible employees may enroll in health, dental, vision, retirement, and other available benefit programs subject to state eligibility rules, plan terms, and enrollment deadlines. Official plan documents, carrier materials, and Benefits Administration policies govern all coverage, eligibility determinations, premiums, claims, and benefit administration.



Benefits questions? Contact the Director of Operations at hr@invictus-nash.org, or call Benefits Administration directly at **800.253.9981** (Mon–Fri, 8 AM–4:30 PM CT).

Who Is Eligible

The following employees are eligible for health, dental, and vision coverage:

- Teachers and certified staff (as defined under T.C.A. § 8-34-101(49))
- Full-time employees regularly scheduled to work at least 30 hours per week

Eligible dependents include your legally married spouse, natural or adopted children, stepchildren, and children for whom you are the legal guardian or conservator. Dependent children are generally eligible through the last day of the month of their 26th birthday.

Enrollment

You must enroll within **30 calendar days** of your hire date. Coverage begins on the first day of the month following your hire date. Enroll through Edison at edison.tn.gov or contact the Director of Operations for assistance.

DON'T WAIT

Enrolling quickly avoids the risk of double premium deductions. If you miss the 30-day window, you must wait for the Annual Enrollment period unless you experience a qualifying life event.

Health Insurance — Plan Options

Through Partners for Health, you can choose from four health plans. All plans cover the same services; the difference is your monthly premium vs. out-of-pocket costs when you use care.

Premier PPO

HIGHEST PREMIUM

Highest monthly premium, lowest out-of-pocket costs (deductible, copays, coinsurance).

Standard PPO

MID-RANGE

Mid-range premium, moderate out-of-pocket costs.

Limited PPO

LOWER PREMIUM

Lower premium, higher out-of-pocket costs than other PPOs.

Local CDHP/HSA

LOWEST PREMIUM

Lowest monthly premium. Pairs with a Health Savings Account (HSA). You pay your full deductible before the plan pays for most services, then coinsurance.

Health Insurance — Network Options

You choose both a plan and a network. Two networks are available through each carrier:

● BCBST Network S / Cigna LocalPlus

Efficient networks. Lower premiums. Includes 95%+ of providers in the expanded networks. Best choice if your providers participate.

■ BCBST Network P / Cigna Open Access Plus

Expanded networks with more hospitals. Higher monthly premiums (\$90–\$180/month more depending on tier). You may also pay more per claim.

CHECK YOUR PROVIDERS FIRST

Your network choice is locked for the full calendar year (Jan. 1 – Dec. 31). Verify your doctors are in-network before enrolling. A provider leaving a network mid-year is not a qualifying event.

Employee Contribution Rates

Current employee payroll deduction rates for medical, dental, and vision coverage are provided in a separate annual benefits rate document. Contact the Director of Operations at hr@invictus-nash.org for the current rate sheet. Rates are determined through the State of Tennessee benefits program and may change annually at open enrollment.

Qualifying Life Events (QLEs)

Outside of Annual Enrollment, you may only make changes to your coverage if you experience a qualifying life event. You have 30–60 days from the event to submit a change, depending on the type. Notify the Director of Operations immediately when a life event occurs.

- Birth or adoption of a child
- Marriage or divorce
- Loss or gain of coverage through a spouse's employer
- Death of a covered dependent
- Change from full-time to part-time status (or reverse)

Annual Enrollment

Each fall, Partners for Health opens an Annual Enrollment period. This is your opportunity to change plans, networks, or coverage tiers for the following calendar year (effective January 1). Information is sent to employees and posted at tn.gov/partnersforhealth. Review it carefully — elections remain in effect for the full calendar year.

Retirement

Certified Staff

Eligible certified employees participate in Tennessee public educator retirement programs administered through RetireReadyTN and the Tennessee Consolidated Retirement System (TCRS). Depending on eligibility, prior service history, and date of hire, employees may participate in either the Legacy Plan or Hybrid Retirement Plan established under Tennessee law. These programs may include pension retirement benefits, employee and employer retirement contributions, disability and survivor protections, and optional supplemental retirement savings opportunities through state-sponsored 401(k) programs.

Certain eligible employees are automatically enrolled in required retirement contribution programs in accordance with Tennessee retirement plan requirements. Retirement eligibility, vesting, contribution requirements, and plan provisions are governed by applicable state law and official plan documents.

Support & Non-Certified Staff

At this time, Invictus Nashville does not offer an employer-sponsored retirement plan for support staff or non-certified employees. The school may evaluate additional retirement benefit offerings in the future based on organizational growth, financial sustainability, and available program options.

Workers' Compensation

If you are injured on the job, report it immediately to the Director of Operations, who will assist with filing a claim. Failure to report promptly may result in reduced or denied benefits. Invictus Nashville carries paid workers' compensation coverage that may cover lost wages and related medical expenses.

SECTION 10

PAID TIME OFF & LEAVE

PTO Overview

Paid Time Off (PTO) covers all absences including illness, personal needs, appointments, and family matters. There is one combined PTO bank. No distinction is made between “sick” and “personal” days. Refer to the school calendar for designated holidays and closure periods, which do not count against your PTO balance.

School calendar • 10-month

10 days (80 hours) annually. Accrues at 3.63 hours per instructional pay period beginning with the first paycheck of the school year.

Calendar year • 12-month

15 days (120 hours) annually. Accrues at 4.61 hours per pay period across 26 pay periods.

Part-time

PTO accrual is prorated based on scheduled hours.

What Happens When You Run Out

We want to be direct about this so there are no surprises. If you exhaust your PTO bank and need additional time off, those additional days are **unpaid**. The cost is deducted from your next paycheck at your daily rate. The school does not absorb this cost, and it is not forgiven at year end.

HOW YOUR DAILY RATE IS CALCULATED

Your annual salary divided by the number of contracted work days in your employment year. This is the amount deducted per unpaid day. This is not meant to be punitive — it is simply how the math works. The best protection is knowing where you stand throughout the year. Your current PTO balance is visible in Paylocity at any time.

Requesting PTO

All PTO requests must be submitted through Paylocity.

- Submit planned PTO requests at least 10 days in advance whenever possible.
- Absence reporting and call-out expectations are outlined earlier in this handbook and reviewed during staff training.
- PTO must be approved before it is considered authorized.
- PTO cannot be used during your final two weeks of employment or to extend a termination date.
- Requests for more than three consecutive days may require supporting documentation.

Doctor's Notes

A doctor's note is required when:

- Three or more consecutive days are missed for illness.
- An absence falls immediately before or after a holiday, professional development day, or state testing period.

A pattern of frequent absences raises concern regarding attendance reliability. Failure to provide required documentation may result in the absence being treated as unpaid regardless of PTO balance.

PTO Sell-Back

At the end of the school year, employees with unused PTO days may sell back up to 3 days. Sell-back is paid at a flat rate of \$150 per day and is included in the first payroll of the following school year.

- You must be actively employed through the payout date to be eligible.
- PTO does not roll over. Any days not used or sold back are forfeited at year end.

WHY SELL-BACK EXISTS

We want to reward staff who show up consistently. If you made it through the year without needing your full bank, you should see something for that.

Critical Days

Certain days throughout the school year are designated Critical Days because employee absences create significant disruption to students, staffing, testing, compliance, or school operations. Critical Days may include, but are not limited to:

- Professional development and staff workdays
- State and district testing windows, including TNReady, MAP, EOC, benchmark, and AP testing
- The first and last week of school
- Enrollment, orientation, or family event days requiring full staffing
- Days immediately before or after school breaks or holidays
- Major schoolwide events, performances, exhibitions, or compliance visits
- Other dates designated by school leadership in advance

PTO requests on Critical Days may be denied based on operational needs. If an employee is absent on a Critical Day due to illness, supporting documentation may be required.

Unapproved absences on Critical Days may result in unpaid leave and/or disciplinary action, even if PTO is otherwise available.

Paid Holidays & School Closure Periods

Paid holidays and scheduled school closure periods are designated annually on the approved school calendar. Employees should refer to the current school calendar for the full list of non-instructional days each year.

Historically, designated periods have included days such as New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Good Friday, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Veterans Day, Thanksgiving, and Christmas, as well as scheduled school breaks. The specific days observed each year are set by the school calendar and may vary.

Holidays falling on weekends are generally observed on the closest weekday. In rare cases where staff are required to work during a designated closure, additional PTO may be provided with prior leadership approval.

Bereavement Leave

Up to one week of paid leave is available following the loss of an immediate family member or loved one. Notify your manager as soon as possible.

Jury Duty & Voting

Provide documentation of jury duty as soon as received. The school will adjust schedules and compensate in accordance with state law. Employees needing time to vote must notify their manager in advance — schedules will be adjusted as needed.

Military Leave

Invictus Nashville complies fully with USERRA. Employees returning from military service will be reinstated to their previous or equivalent position, subject to the law's conditions.

Parental Leave

This policy applies to full-time, benefits-eligible employees who have been employed for at least 6 consecutive months.

Primary caregiver

Up to 10 weeks paid parental leave following birth, adoption, or stillbirth.

Non-primary caregiver

Up to 6 weeks paid parental leave following birth, adoption, or stillbirth.

● Leave structure

Must be taken consecutively, commencing with the qualifying event.

● Benefits during leave

Health coverage continues. Employees continue paying their share of premiums.

One leave period is provided per event (e.g., twins count as one event). Notify your manager and HR (hr@invictus-nash.org) at least 30 days before your anticipated leave start date. Parental leave runs concurrently with FMLA when applicable.

Family Medical Leave (FMLA)

Eligible employees are entitled to up to 12 weeks of unpaid leave per year for qualifying family and medical reasons. To qualify, you must have worked at Invictus Nashville for at least one year and logged at least 1,250 hours in the preceding 12 months.

Qualifying reasons include

- Birth or placement of a child for adoption or foster care
- Care for a spouse, child, or parent with a serious health condition
- Your own serious health condition that prevents you from performing your job

- Qualifying military exigency involving a covered family member

How to request

- Provide at least 30 days' advance notice when possible.
- Complete INCS's FMLA Request Form and submit required medical certifications from your healthcare provider.
- HR will issue a Notice of Eligibility and Designation Notice within five business days of receiving your request.

FMLA leave runs concurrently with PTO. Health coverage continues during FMLA leave. Employees return to their same or equivalent position after leave.

MILITARY CAREGIVING

Eligible employees caring for a covered injured military service member may take up to 26 weeks of leave during a single 12-month period.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF RECEIPT

By signing below, I confirm that:

- I have received and read the Invictus Nashville Charter School Employee Handbook for the 2026–2027 academic year.
- I understand the policies and expectations outlined in this handbook and agree to comply with them as a condition of my employment.
- I understand that this handbook is not a contract of employment and does not create an implied contract or guarantee of employment for any specific period of time. Signing this acknowledgment does not alter the at-will nature of my employment.
- I understand that my employment is at-will, meaning either I or Invictus Nashville may end the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause or advance notice.
- I understand that policies in this handbook may be updated at any time and that I will be notified of material changes.
- I may request a printed copy of this handbook at any time.

EMPLOYEE SIGNATURE

PRINTED NAME

DATE

TITLE / ROLE

MANAGER SIGNATURE

DATE



Submit signed acknowledgment to hr@invictus-nash.org. This signed acknowledgment will be placed in your personnel file.

APPENDIX

REQUIRED FEDERAL NOTICE

Nondiscrimination Statement

In accordance with federal civil rights law and U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) civil rights regulations and policies, this institution is prohibited from discriminating on the basis of race, color, national origin, sex (including gender identity and sexual orientation), disability, age, or reprisal or retaliation for prior civil rights activity.

Program information may be made available in languages other than English. Persons with disabilities who require alternative means of communication to obtain program information (e.g., Braille, large print, audiotape, American Sign Language) should contact the responsible state or local agency that administers the program or USDA's TARGET Center at (202) 720-2600 (voice and TTY) or contact USDA through the Federal Relay Service at (800) 877-8339.

To file a program discrimination complaint, complete Form AD-3027 at usda.gov or call (866) 632-9992. Submit to USDA by mail: 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, D.C. 20250-9410; fax: (833) 256-1665; or email: OAC@usda.gov.

This institution is an equal opportunity provider.

NOTICE

This notice is required by the U.S. Department of Agriculture and is included in compliance with federal civil rights law applicable to institutions participating in federal nutrition programs, including the National School Lunch Program (NSLP).